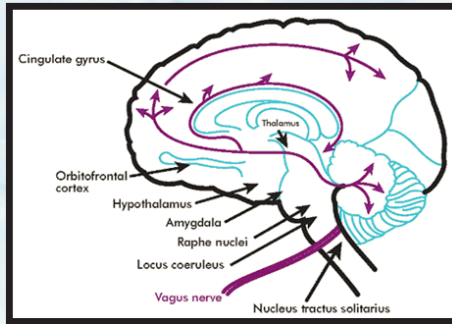


WHAT IS Vagus Nerve?

A major nerve that is linked to your brain stem, limbic systems (emotional parts of the brain), parasympathetic nervous systems. It connects and detects many parts of your body without awareness.



HOW THE VAGUS NERVE AFFECTS YOUR BODY

Changes in Hormones:

Adrenal medulla to release epinephrine (adrenaline) and norepinephrine (noradrenaline) into the bloodstream.

Changes in Involuntary body responses:

- Stress hormones prepare body for fight, flight, freeze, or placate
- Heart rate
- Sweating hands
- Energy conservation
- Lungs
- Digestion and immune system shut down
- Trouble focusing on small tasks (brain is directed to focus only on big picture in order to determine where threat is coming from)
- Learning becomes difficult
- Memory hard to recall or even lost for a time

FAST FACTS:

- Our nervous system is continuously evaluating risk in the environment
 - Continuously making judgments and prioritizing behaviors
- Cues of a life threat trigger the vagal circuit.
- We don't have control over this circuit
- This occurs sub-consciously
- Our logical brain (frontal lobe) shuts down
- NO logical decisions can be made
- Animal brain takes over and makes **SURVIVAL** decisions

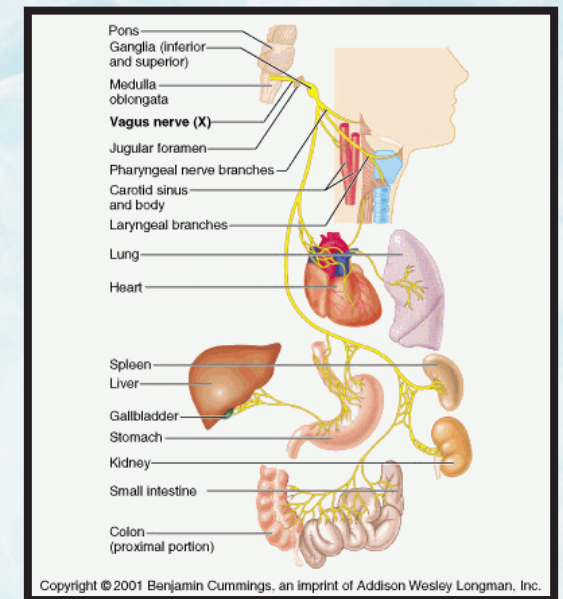
Our nervous system has more than one defense strategy:

Fight
Flight
Freeze
AND in DV: Placate

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PTSD IN DOMESTIC VIOLENCE POLYVAGAL THEORY



Healing
Domestic
Violence
and PTSD

HYPER-AROUSAL

Anxiety (Thinking about the future)

- Overwhelmed
- Chaotic thinking
- Impulsivity
- OCD behaviors
- Overeating
- Addictions

How to get back into the Window:

- Maybe get up and move around
- What is going on right this minute?
(Stay in the present moment)

Olfactory sensation-Straight to the brain
Mint, Altoids, soothing smell

Fight Flight

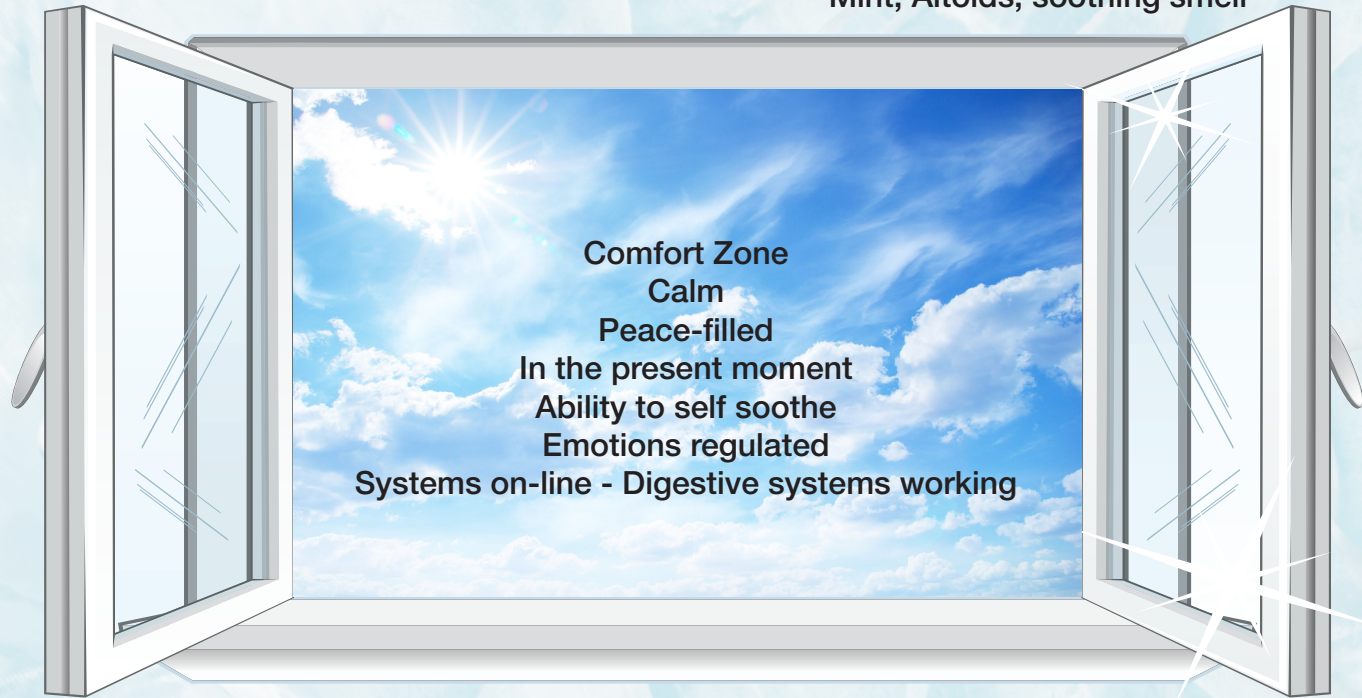
WINDOW OF TOLERANCE

Description of what happens when
out of the window of tolerance:

Your vagus nerve determines your safety
within the environment around you.

Your logical brain shuts down
NO logical decisions can be made, even if
you wanted to make logical decisions you
could not. Your animal brain (the limbic
system or the emotional part of your brain)
takes over to keep you safe and chooses
fight, flight, freeze, or placate.

Bouncing back and forth between hyper
and hypo arousal is common in DV and
trauma victims.



Comfort Zone
Calm
Peace-filled
In the present moment
Ability to self soothe
Emotions regulated
Systems on-line - Digestive systems working

HYPO-AROUSAL

Depression - Thinking about the Past
Thinking about things we can not change

Can not focus, foggy thinking

- Sleepy
- Dissociation
- Memory Loss
- Lack of desire
- Auto-Pilot

Separation from self and emotions

How to get back into the Window:

- Maybe get up and move around
- What is going on right this minute?
(Stay in the present moment)

Mindfulness

Techniques for grounding soothing sounds,
smells, safe environment

Freeze Placate